

Financial Aid Award Comparison

FILL IN TOGETHER

Award letters are written to look generous. This puts them in the same format so you can see what each school actually costs you — the number nobody prints in bold.

When: March and April of senior year, as offers arrive

Take every figure from the award letter. Where a school does not state one, write "not stated" — that is itself an answer.

	College 1	College 2	College 3	College 4
A. Tuition and fees				
B. Housing and meals				
C. Books, travel, personal				
D. TOTAL COST (A+B+C)				
E. Grants (never repaid)				
F. Scholarships (never repaid)				
G. TOTAL FREE MONEY (E+F)				
H. Work-study offered				
I. Federal student loans offered				
J. Parent PLUS / private loans offered				
K. WHAT WE PAY (D – G)				
L. Of K, how much is borrowed?				
M. $K \times 4$ years				

Questions to ask the financial aid office

- ☐ Is this scholarship renewable all four years, and what GPA keeps it?
- ☐ Will my aid change if my sibling starts or finishes college?
- ☐ Does the cost figure include the health insurance charge?
- ☐ Is there an appeal process if our circumstances have changed?

Our decision

WORTH KNOWING

- ◆ A loan is not aid. It is a bill that arrives later, with interest.
- ◆ Row K is the only number that compares schools. Row D is marketing.
- ◆ You may appeal an award. A short, factual letter about changed circumstances works more often than families expect.